

MASSMUTUAL | MAX TRAINING - MS-4004
FINANCE

Finance Work That Survives Review

Scott Hay - Delivered with MAX Training



One review pack, four stages

01 Excel fundamentals

Ask, calculate, chart, explain - then make Excel yours

02 Create

Interrogate the workbook and identify material findings

03 Refine

Rank, structure, and make the analysis management-relevant

04 Verify claims

Reconcile every material statement to source data

05 Prepare to present

Build a concise management narrative and question list

OPERATING RULES

Quality Inputs + Vetted Outputs

Copilot requires quality inputs and vetted outputs



Quality in

Goal, Context, Source, Expectations. Name all four and the answer changes.



Vetted out

Green ship it, yellow fix it, red start over. You make that call, not Copilot.



No prior session required - every rule this room needs today is on this slide.

MODULE 1 - EXCEL FUNDAMENTALS

Put Copilot to work in Excel

Ask, calculate, chart, and explain - before you ask for analysis.

OBJECTIVE · MS-4004 Finance: use Microsoft 365 Copilot in Excel to interrogate, calculate, and visualize source data



What Copilot in Excel can do



Ask

Question your table in plain language - summaries, trends, outliers.



Add a column

Describe the calculation; Copilot writes the column and explains it.



Chart it

Describe the chart; Copilot builds it linked to the source data.



Highlight and sort

Surface top values or a filtered view - Copilot describes it, you press Apply.



Explain a formula

Select an inherited formula and get it back in plain language.



Copilot editing needs Calculation Options set to Automatic and a modern .xlsx file.

Ask the workbook what it holds

What you are practicing

- Name the table, never 'this data'
- Description first, explanation never
- Check the new column against Variance
- File: Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

What does the PerformanceData table contain? Describe the columns and the period covered.

2

Add a column to PerformanceData showing Actual minus Plan for each row.

See the shape before the story

What you are practicing

- 'Unusual' is a description, not a cause
- Always ask why it was flagged
- A chart is a claim you can eyeball
- File: Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx

PASTE THIS

- 1** Which rows in PerformanceData look unusual compared to the rest of the year? Explain why you flagged each one.
- 2** Create a chart of Paid Claims by month, Actual versus Plan.

GUIDED DEMONSTRATION

Explain the formula you inherited



GUIDED

- 1** Open Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx
- 2** Select a Variance cell in PerformanceData
- 3** Ask Copilot to explain the selected formula

Decide before Copilot writes



Allow editing

- Copilot writes into the sheet
- Changes save as they happen
- Work on a copy of anything critical



Chat only

- Answers stay in the pane
- The workbook does not move
- Where to start on a file you do not own



Copilot's edits save automatically and are visible to everyone who can open the file.

MAKE EXCEL YOURS - PASTE THIS

Tell Excel how you work, once

What you are practicing

- Preferences, not a prompt
- Saved to you, never to the file
- Say the convention once
- Your teammates set their own

PASTE THIS

1

Format currency as US dollars with thousand separators and no decimals. Call variances favorable or unfavorable, never positive or negative. When you state a number, name the sheet and the row it came from.

2

Summarize the June rows in PerformanceData.

Promote the clause to a rule

What you are practicing

- A rule rides with the workbook
- Encode the convention, not the answer
- Repeated clause today, rule tomorrow
- File: Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

Add a workbook rule: revenue below plan is unfavorable, and claims or operating expense above plan is unfavorable.

2

Rank the five largest unfavorable variances in PerformanceData.

Skills do the repeatable part



What a skill is

Saved instructions for a repeatable task, called by name.



How you pick one

The plus menu lists them; type @ and the name to call one.



What is on your shelf

Varies by account and build - read your own list before you promise one.



Who publishes them

Ask IT. Authoring and sharing skills is not a finance decision.



Turning a skill off stops it running on its own - it still runs when you name it with @.

A plausible cause is still a hypothesis

“

Facts come from the workbook.

“

Causes need supporting evidence.

“

Questions belong in the review pack, not hidden in prose.

MODULE 2 - CONTROLS

Control the work before it ships

Four controls turn a fast answer into a defensible one.

OBJECTIVE • MS-4004 Finance: prepare source files and control Copilot-assisted finance analysis end to end





KEY CONCEPT

The Verified Finance Review Pack

A management narrative with an evidence trail.



Material findings - ranked facts from the workbook



Explanations - supported drivers separated from hypotheses



Claim ledger - source, check, status, and owner



Management brief - concise narrative plus open questions

From workbook to review pack



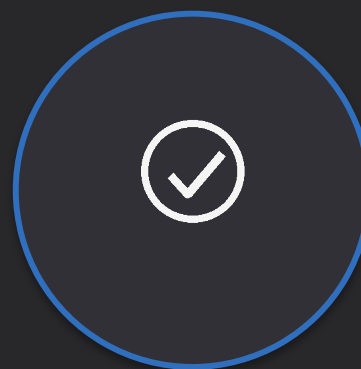
Create

find material facts



Refine

rank for audience



Verify

trace each claim



Present

brief + questions

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Begin with an analysis contract

What you are practicing

- Name the table and period
- Ask for materiality and ranking
- Separate facts from causes
- Require formulas or source references

PASTE THIS

1

Using PerformanceData, rank the five largest unfavorable variances by absolute dollars. Revenue below plan and Claims or Expense above plan are unfavorable. Show amount, percentage, month, and category. Do not infer causes.

2

For each finding, cite the exact row or formula and flag any data-quality issue that could change the result.

MODULE 3 - CREATE AND REFINE

Turn the table into findings

Accelerate the analysis without surrendering the judgment.

OBJECTIVE • MS-4004 Finance: analyze financial data with Copilot in Excel and refine insights for stakeholders





KEY CONCEPT

Northstar monthly performance

A fictional dataset built for checkable analysis.



Premium - actual, plan, and favorability by month



Claims - paid claims plus monthly loss-ratio context



Expense - operating expense and prior-month comparison



Quality controls - owner and neutral data-quality flags

Create the first analysis



DEMO

- 1** Open PerformanceData in Northstar_Life_Monthly_Performance.xlsx
- 2** Run the ranked-variance contract prompt
- 3** Recalculate the top row in Excel

Make analysis management-relevant

01

Rank

materiality
first

>

02

Group

driver not
noise

>

03

Delta

plan + prior
period

>

04

Test

weak
causes

>

05

Format

decision
brief

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Refine for management attention

What you are practicing

- Rank by materiality
- Use finance language precisely
- Separate supported driver from hypothesis
- File: Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx

PASTE THIS

1

Reframe the analysis for a finance director. Lead with the three material findings, quantify each, and separate supported explanations from hypotheses.

2

After opening the review notes, state which hypotheses the notes support, contradict, or leave unresolved. Do not upgrade a hypothesis to fact without direct evidence.

LIVE DEMONSTRATION

Refine without inventing cause



DEMO

- 1 Freeze the ranked output first
- 2 Open Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx
- 3 Scope every explanation to its note

MODULE 4 - VERIFY AND PRESENT

Verify every material claim

Make the evidence trail visible before the narrative ships.

OBJECTIVE - MS-4004 Finance: validate Copilot-generated financial analysis, retain human accountability, and communicate the result





KEY CONCEPT

The claim-verification chain

Every consequential sentence earns a status.



Claim - exact sentence proposed for the brief



Source - table, row, formula, or approved note



Check - recalculate or reconcile



Owner - person who approves or resolves

Four statuses, no ambiguity

STATUS	MEANING
Verified	Source and calculation support the claim
Supported	Evidence points the same way; limits remain
Hypothesis	Plausible but not evidenced enough
Blocked	Data or approval is missing

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Make Copilot help you challenge Copilot

What you are practicing

- Extract exact claims
- Demand source and calculation
- Ask what would falsify the claim
- File: Finance_Claim_Ledger.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

Create a claim-verification ledger with columns: claim, source, calculation/check, status, uncertainty, owner. Include only material findings.

2

For each claim, explain what evidence would contradict it or lower confidence.

LIVE DEMONSTRATION

Build the claim ledger



DEMO

- 1** Extract material claims into Finance_Claim_Ledger.xlsx
- 2** Recalculate 858,000 - 790,000 live
- 3** Assign status and owner to each row



KEY CONCEPT

The management narrative

Short because the evidence work is already done.



Headline - what changed and why it matters



Three facts - material, quantified, verified



Open questions - hypotheses and missing evidence



Decision - what management must decide or assign

Draft from the verified ledger

What you are practicing

- Use only Verified or Supported claims
- Keep hypotheses labelled
- Name decisions and owners
- File: Finance_Claim_Ledger.xlsx

PASTE THIS

1

Using only claims marked Verified or Supported in the attached ledger, draft a one-page finance director brief: headline, three material findings, risks, open questions, and decisions needed.

2

Audit the draft against the ledger. Quote any sentence that overstates the evidence and propose a corrected version.

BREAK

Back in 10 minutes



YOUR TURN - 40 MIN

Lab: build the review pack



Step 1

Run the create prompt on the workbook



Step 2

Refine the top findings



Step 3

Complete at least three ledger rows



Step 4

Draft the one-page brief



Leave with: Verified Finance Review Pack

Ready for management?

CHECK	PASS WHEN
Material	The brief leads with consequential findings
Traceable	Every number maps to a source/check
Honest	Hypotheses and blocked items are labeled
Actionable	Decisions and owners are explicit
Concise	A finance director can scan it quickly

THE KEEPS - TAKE THESE WITH YOU

Take the keeps home

Three things that outlive today

- Save the analysis contract to Prompt Lab
- The claim ledger is your reusable template
- FLEX: forecast commentary, assumptions labelled
- Everything is in the handout repo

SAVE THESE TWO

1

Using PerformanceData, rank the five largest unfavorable variances by absolute dollars. Revenue below plan and Claims or Expense above plan are unfavorable. Show amount, percentage, month, and category. Do not infer causes.

2

Draft a forecast commentary for Q3 Paid Claims using only the trend visible in PerformanceData; label every assumption.

REMEMBER THIS

Create faster. Verify before trust.

“

Copilot accelerates the work.

“

The ledger makes judgment visible.

“

The finance owner approves the narrative.

Bring the loop back to real work

Next review

Start with a controlled source set and a claim ledger.

Office hours

1:00-3:00. Bring a workflow and an approved, non-confidential example.

